SMALL TOWN TYCOONS NORTH

The word tycoon itself brings an aura surrounding it. Tycoons bring in the thoughts of rich industrious mainly businessmen who have fortunes

cornered away in their closets and living a fairytale life in metros of India, be it the IT hub of the country, Bengaluru or the dazzling lifestyle of financial capital and filmy Mumbai or even the techno modern city of Gurugram. A UK-based research group, Hurun India Rich list of 2022, reveals that India's Rich are those whose net worth exceeds Rs1,000 crores and has grown ten-fold to 1,036 individuals in the past decade alone. Another striking point is that out of 178 businessmen so mentioned in the research papers over 60 of them are based in small towns and cities. Setting up businesses in rural and small cities is empowering the local population. The businesses so perceived and incorporated can get local skilled labour of expertise and knowledge due to the setting up of engineering, medical and polytechnics in these far-flung areas. These have mushroomed in these areas so supplying to the local industry. Employees are also happy to get experts within their radius rather than eyeing the IIT and IIM. Over 230 such education hubs have emerged across India post-liberation in the early 1990"s. There are over 3,000 incubation centres across the country, helping new businesses stand independently. These rural places help businesses to acquire large land space at a lower price rather than in prominent cities. The small towns are soon transformed with the new settlement of staff workers of these business establishments. New structures in housing, malls, schools and healthcare come up giving the opportunity to realtors to develop new housing projects for business officials. The new scale in the urbanization of the area speaks of world-class structures. Developers like Jagjit Singh Majha comes up with a 200-acre housing complex wherein he provides the green building with open spaces to live in a free air and cleaner environment in New Chandigarh. A revolutionary dream that each dweller dreams of when he lives amongst birds, trees, lush green parks, luxury and daily needs all catered for nearby plus modern housing structures that are cosy and comfortable at an affordable rate. Hampton Homes, in Ludhiana, also speak of offering affordable housing with all facilities that one can think of. Hemant Sood, Managing Director of Findoc Investmart Private Limited, based in Ludhiana is coming up with these homes. His own parent company caters to investment guidance and has branches all over the North and soon to be brought in the south as well.

Rajinder Gupta, RG to his peers, has a chain of business ventures in Ludhiana, Barnala, Punjab, and Budhni, Madhya Pradesh, et al. In 2022, Trident Limited's extraordinarily high earnings have pushed RG's net worth to a level that has made him the richest billionaire in Punjab. His saga of success speaks volumes of his resilience and mercurial rise to attain a place of pride in the business world. By giving employment to a large rural population the Group earns the goodwill and blessings of the local people.

Meanwhile, Vardhman Group has emerged as a reliable and famous business model and under the young dynamic leadership of Suchita Oswal Jain the group surges ahead of the rest and wins hands down as the leading industrial magnates. Starting operation in 1965 with just 6,000 spindles, Today, the Group employs more than 30,000 people in 20 production units spread over 5 states of India- Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Tamil Nadu. They export the bulk of their production to 65 countries around the globe and their products are sold under various known branded stores. They are looking ahead to more expansions and are going for foreign collaborations for better production. Punjab ranks 13th among 20 states and union territories in the country. Neighbouring Haryana is five ranks ahead, at the 8th position, with 29 industrialists from the state. As many as 18 of them are from Gurugram.

While Gupta, who recently stepped down from the board of directors of Trident Group citing health and family issues, ranks 127th in the country, SP Oswal of Vardhman textiles stands second in Punjab with wealth totalling ₹4,600 crores. Oswal ranks 349th in the country.

"India is seeing a very exciting phase, where innovation is moving deeper into the country, beyond the metros and Tier 1 cities, " says Vikram Gandhi, a senior lecturer at the Harvard Business School. This holds true as we explore and find the flourishing businesses in small towns as compared to collapsing and polluted cities. As the decade unfolds more businesses and India's rich will come from towns rarely heard of. Herein explore the small town tycoons with us as we unfold some of them in the North.